

Preaching in the Patristic Era

Sermons, Preachers, and Audiences in the Latin West

Edited by

Anthony Dupont

Shari Boodts

Gert Partoens

Johan Leemans



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Augustine of Hippo

Shari Boodts and Anthony Dupont

1 Introduction

Saint Augustine, 354-430 AD, was ordained as a priest by Bishop Valerius of Hippo between 390-91 AD. Valerius gave the young priest permission to preach, a privilege which at that time was normally reserved for bishops. Such an exception was likely made because Valerius needed help in the heated controversy with the Donatists: the bishop's mother tongue was Greek and he did not have sufficient confidence in his Latin to engage in debates. When Augustine succeeded Valerius on the *sedes* of Hippo around 396, he considered this preaching ministry to be one of his most important episcopal duties. His solicitude to deliver good sermons is attested to by the roughly 900 sermons extant today, which probably represent a mere ten percent of the sermons Augustine actually gave. Possidius of Calama, Augustine's biographer, notes that Augustine's preaching attracted large audiences and that his immediate environment profited more from his homilies than from his writings.¹

Augustine preached invariably on Sundays and from time to time also on Saturdays and feast days. During specific liturgical periods he was known to preach on a daily basis, and sometimes more than once on the same day. His preaching activity was not solely confined to the Eucharist, but included the occasional sermon during other liturgical services such as evening prayer and vigils. Augustine preached primarily in Hippo, but also elsewhere when invited to do so by other bishops. He was a popular 'visiting preacher' in Carthage, for instance.²

Augustine's homiletic oeuvre is traditionally divided into three categories: *sermones*, *tractatus*, and *enarrationes*. The circa 580 *sermones ad populum* considered to be authentic are usually divided into four groups: *de scripturis* (s. 1-183), *de tempore* (s. 184-272), *de sanctis* (s. 273-340), *de diuersis* (s. 341-95). *Sermones* discovered at a later date – the so-called *post Maurinos reperti* – have been ascribed the number attached to related existing *sermones*, together with

1 Possidius Calamensis, *Life of Augustine*, ed. W. Geerlings, *Vita Augustini* (Augustinus. Opera-
Werke, o), Paderborn 2005, 5, 2-5; 7, 3; 9, 1; 31, 9.

2 See Perler/Maier, *Les voyages de saint Augustin*, for a reconstruction of Augustine's travels.

a distinguishing letter. Augustine created 124 *tractatus* on the Gospel of John and ten on the First Letter of John. He composed 205 *enarrationes* on the 150 Psalms. The most fundamental difference between the *sermones* and the *enarrationes/tractatus* is that the latter were later edited by Augustine. A number of the homilies in this second category, moreover, were never delivered. Some were dictated by Augustine as commentaries on the Scriptures, while others were put together as model sermon examples for other preachers and were never preached by Augustine to a congregation. Augustine himself stated at the end of his life that he intended to edit the *sermones* as well (*Retr.* 2, 67), but in reality he was never able to realize this plan. Additionally, there are also a few isolated sermons published by Augustine as separate tractates: *Sermo ad Caesariensis ecclesiae plebem*, *De disciplina Christiana*, *De excidio urbis Romae*, *De Symbolo ad catechumenis* and *De utilitate ieiunii*. This contribution will focus exclusively on Augustine's 'typical' sermons – mainly to be found in the *sermones ad populum* – and disregard the 'desktop sermons', which more closely resemble Augustine's literary treatises than his activity as a preacher.

2 Formal/Material

2.1 *The Transmission of the Sermones ad Populum*

The transmission of Augustine's sermons is due to the work of *notarii*, ancient stenographers or tachygraphs taking notes during the delivery of the sermons. These persons were either Augustine's own *notarii* or those of prosperous believers. The late-antique transmission of sermons based on such records did not take the form of an exhaustive body containing all texts, but mainly of a number of different collections. Though there are indications that Augustine edited some of his sermons after they were written down (cf. *supra*), he did not systematically organize them in collections himself. Even so, manuscripts containing large selections of sermons were available in the library at Hippo for visitors, who could copy them. Very early, during Augustine's lifetime, some of these compilations, as well as compilations derived from sources outside of Hippo (especially sermons preached in Carthage), crossed the Mediterranean to Europe, where they underwent further intentional and unintentional changes.

The sermon collections are traditionally divided into three groups:³ (1) Antique collections, which go back more or less directly to African sources: *De*

3 Lambot, *Sermones de vetere Testamento*, pp. VII-XXXV; Verbraken, *Études critiques*, pp. 197-234; Verbraken/De Coninck/Coppieters 't Wallant/Demeulenaere/Dolbeau, *Sermones in Matthaeum I*, pp. VII-LXXVII.

alleluia,⁴ *De paenitentia*, *Collectio Sessoriana*,⁵ *Collectio Cartusiana*,⁶ *Collectio Bobbiensis*, *Collectio Cluniacensis*, *Collectio Campana*,⁷ *Collectio Colbertina*;⁸ (2) Arlesian collections, named after Caesarius of Arles († 542 AD), who compiled large selections of Augustine's homiletic oeuvre and significantly adapted and intertwined the texts with his own sermons in order to provide sample material for the clergy of Southern Gaul: *Quinquaginta homiliae*,⁹ *De bono coniugali*, *Collectio Lugdunensis*, the collection of *Marmoutier*; (3) Medieval collections, which mostly consist of material taken from the two previous categories: *De uerbis domini et apostoli*,¹⁰ *De diuersis rebus*,¹¹ *De lapsu mundi*,¹² *Sancti Catholici Patres*,¹³ *Collectio tripartita*,¹⁴ *Collectio Bruxellensis*, *Collectorium of Roberto de' Bardi*.¹⁵

In addition to the transmission in collections, Augustine's sermons have also been preserved in numerous eclectic manuscripts or *recueils mixtes*, which contain a unique combination of texts. A special category here is reserved for *homiliaria*.¹⁶

- 4 Lambot, "Collection antique de sermons de saint Augustin".
- 5 Wilmart, "Remarques sur plusieurs collections des sermons de saint Augustin"; Partoens, "La collection de sermons augustinien *De uerbis Apostoli*", esp. pp. 329-38.
- 6 Lambot, *Sermones selecti*; Dolbeau, *Vingt-six sermons*; Dolbeau, *Augustin et la prédication en Afrique*, pp. 23-70.
- 7 Cf. n. 6.
- 8 Bouhot, "N° 67 of the *Bulletin Augustinien pour 1980*".
- 9 Boodts, "The manuscript transmission of the *Quinquaginta homiliae*".
- 10 De Coninck/Coppieters 't Wallant/Demeulenaere, *La tradition manuscrite du recueil De uerbis Domini*; Boodts/Partoens, "The Manuscript Transmission of the *De uerbis Apostoli* Collection".
- 11 De Ghellinck, "Une édition ou une collection médiévale".
- 12 Boodts, "A new critical edition of Augustine's *sermo 170*".
- 13 Bouhot, "L'homélaire des Sancti catholici Patres. Sources et composition"; Bouhot, "L'homélaire des Sancti catholici Patres. Tradition manuscrite"; Bouhot, "L'homélaire des Sancti catholici Patres. Reconstitution de sa forme originale".
- 14 Wilmart, "La collection Tripartite des sermons de saint Augustin".
- 15 Pozzi, "La 'Tabula' di Jean de Fayt al 'Collectorium' di Roberto de' Bardi"; Pozzi, "Roberto de' Bardi e s. Agostino".
- 16 There are several patristic *homiliaria* of the 8th to 10th centuries in which Augustine plays a prominent role and which seem to have an African basis, e.g. Orléans, Bibliothèque municipale, 155 + Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, n.a.l. 1598-99, copied around 750 for Fleury-sur-Loire, Vienna, Österreichische Nationalbibliothek, lat. 1616 (8th century from Novare), Vatican City, Biblioteca Apostolica Vaticana, Vat. lat. 3828 (9th century), and above all the *homiliarium* of Wolfenbüttel, which has been transmitted in Wolfenbüttel, Herzog August Bibliothek, Weiss. 12 [Guelf. 4096]. Several prominent lectionaries are based on a 7th-century *homiliarium* connected with the basilica of St. Peter in Rome: the *homiliarium* of Agimundus (Vat. lat. 3835/6, 8th century), a later version of

The first editions of larger corpora of Augustinian sermons focused mostly on pseudo-epigraphical material. The *Quinquaginta homiliae* were among the first to be edited in Cologne and Augsburg in 1470. The first major edition of Augustine's sermons, and the *editio princeps* for four of the five sermon collections it includes was published in 1494 in Basel by Johannes Amerbach. Subsequent important editions, largely based on Amerbach's, include those of Gering and Remboldt (Paris, 1498), and of Froben and Erasmus (Basel, 1528-29). Vlimmerius was responsible for the *editio princeps* of an additional forty-two sermons in his edition (Leuven, 1564), as well as several revisions, including the revision of the *theologi Louanienses* edition (Antwerp, 1576-77). Further significant contributions to the published corpus were made by Sirmond (Paris, 1631) and Vignier (1654). The most recent complete edition was produced by the French Benedictine congregation of Saint-Maur in 1683. This text, with slight modifications by the Brothers Gaume (Paris, 1836-39), found its way into Migne's *Patrologia Latina* 38 and 39.¹⁷

The elaborate system of classification of the sermon collections testifies to a grand research tradition, which is centered around four Benedictines, three of whom belonged to the Belgian community of Maredsous: G. Morin, A. Wilmart, C. Lambot, and P.-P. Verbraken. In addition to their groundwork, several more recent discoveries have shed new light on the transmission of the sermons. The most important of these is the discovery made by F. Dolbeau of twenty-six previously unknown sermons in the codex Mainz, Stadtbibliothek, 19.¹⁸ Recently, in Erfurt, four completely new sermons and two which were previously known only in an abridged form, were found in the 12th-century manuscript Erfurt, Universitätsbibliothek, Dep. Erf. CA. 12^o11.¹⁹ At the time of the Maurist edition the authentic Augustinian sermons numbered 396. Research over the past century has increased this number by nearly 200 (fragments included) and additional discoveries in the future are very likely.

The state of the transmission is such that the majority of Augustinian sermons each have a unique transmission pattern, i.e., a presence in a combination of collections, eclectic witnesses and/or indirect sources that does not occur in an identical fashion for any other sermon. The most important aid to gain

the St. Peter *homiliarium* (Vat. Arch. S. Pietro C 105, 9th-10th century), the *homiliarium* of bishop Egino of Verona (Berlin, Staatsbibliothek, Phillips 1676, 8th century), and the *homiliarium* of Alanus of Farfa.

17 See Partoens/Boodts/Eelen, "Sermones ad populum", for a more detailed overview of the editions of Augustine's sermons.

18 Dolbeau, *Vingt-six sermons*.

19 Schiller/Weber/Weidmann, "Sechs neue Augustinuspredigten"; Weidmann, "The Corpus of Augustinian Sermons Recently Discovered at Erfurt".

insight into the manuscript transmission of a particular text is the ongoing series published by the Österreichischen Akademie der Wissenschaften, *Die handschriftliche Überlieferung der Werke des heiligen Augustinus* (1969-). For the majority of the *sermones ad populum*, Migne's *Patrologia Latina* still offers the most recent edition today. G. Morin published a new edition of all the *post Maurinos reperti* up to that point in 1930.²⁰ Furthermore, there are also various editions of individual sermons published as journal articles. A new complete edition is currently underway in the *Corpus Christianorum's Series Latina*.²¹ To locate the most recent edition of a sermon, the *Augustinus-Lexikon* offers a useful concordance.²²

The vastness of the corpus and the current lack of a complete modern critical edition of the *sermones ad populum* implies a significant unevenness in the quality of the commonly used text of the sermons, a fact which present-day scholars should bear in mind. This is already the case in the 1683 Maurist edition. For those sermons for which the Maurist editors had a complete manuscript transmission, their edition is typically excellent. For example, the new critical edition of s. 171, which occupies columns 933-35 in *Patrologia Latina*, vol. 38, only needed to be adjusted in fifteen *loci*. Where the Maurists' knowledge of the transmission was incomplete, a large number of corrections can sometimes be required. The text of s. 180,²³ which occupied columns 972-79 in *Patrologia Latina*, vol. 38, was adjusted in 144 *loci*.

2.2 The Chronology of the Sermons

The dating and chronology of Augustine's homilies are the subject of a vivid scholarly debate. The first recent attempt to put together a complete chronology of the *Sermones ad populum* was undertaken by A. Kunzelmann in 1931.²⁴ He mainly based his chronology on the four controversies to which Augustine

²⁰ Morin, *Sermones post Maurinos reperti*.

²¹ Modern critical editions of *sermones* 1-51, 51-70, 151-56, 157-83 have been published in, respectively, *Corpus Christianorum Series Latina*, 41, 41Aa, 41Ba, 41Bb. The publication of *sermones* 70-91 is in preparation.

²² Mayer, *Augustinus-Lexikon*, vol. 2, pp. xvi-xxiv. The entry on the *sermones ad populum* for the *Augustinus-Lexikon* is currently being prepared by F. Dolbeau.

²³ Boodts, "Augustine's *sermo* 180 on Iac. 5, 12".

²⁴ Kunzelmann, "Die Chronologie der Sermones des Hl. Augustinus". For overview-chronologies of Augustine's *sermones ad populum*, see Verbraken, *Études critiques*, pp. 53-196. See also Verbraken, "Mise à jour du Fichier signalétique des Sermons de saint Augustin"; Fischer, *Verzeichnis der Sigel*, pp. 116-29; Frede, *Kirchenschriftsteller. Verzeichnis und Sigel*, pp. 221-57; Pellegrino, "General Introduction", esp. pp. 138-63; Gryson/Fischer/Frede, *Répertoire général des auteurs ecclésiastiques Latins*, pp. 231-69. For the link between the

had responded: Manichaeism, Donatism, Arianism, and Pelagianism. He then employed a second point of distinction, namely homilies that contained an indication that they were preached while Augustine was either a priest or a bishop. Kunzelmann located the majority of the *sermones* within the Pelagian period, drafting his chronology within the context of the controversy primarily on content analysis. In addition to scriptural quotations, he employed two main criteria to situate anti-Pelagian *sermones* chronologically within the period of the controversy: the way in which reference is made to the Pelagians and the presence of traces of Augustine's doctrine of predestination. Evidence of concealment or the avoidance of explicit allusion to Pelagianism suggests, in his opinion, a date between 410-16 AD. An explicit reference suggests a post-416 AD date. Kunzelmann thus took 416 AD as a turning point. From this date onwards, Augustine referred to the Pelagians as heretical and his *sermones* contain traces of his doctrine of predestination. In the period from 416-17 AD, Augustine insisted that all human persons were deserving of punishment, and that the human virtues were God's gift from the outset. From 417-18 AD onwards, Augustine dealt with the theme of predestination and the *massa damnata*, and the Pelagians were referred to by name. For Kunzelmann, the presence of elements of Augustine's doctrine of predestination suggested 417-18 AD at the earliest, whereby emphasis on the idea that the *merita* are also *gratia* located the *sermo* in question between 417-20 AD. Kunzelmann listed a series of *sermones* that are anti-Pelagian in terms of content, but likely to be related to the beginning of the controversy, ca. 410-12 AD, on account of their cautious tone. In an additional series of sermons, Augustine's ideas on grace and original sin are more developed and thus to be dated between 412-16 AD.

Kunzelmann's method has been severely criticized. The most fundamental critique is related to Kunzelmann's content-related criteria. The absence of an explicit reference to Pelagianism is no guarantee of an early date and also runs the risk of relying on an *argumentum e silentio*. Recent research into the continuity of Augustine's thought on grace has demonstrated, furthermore, that many anti-Pelagian themes, such as original sin and divine grace, were already present prior to the controversy. For this reason it is virtually impossible to locate a given *sermo* within the said controversy on the mere basis of content. The fact that Augustine preached on the gratuity of grace does not mean that the sermon in which he did so is by definition anti-Pelagian.

The *Nouvelles recherches de chronologie augustiniennne* by P.-M. Hombert has put the issue of the chronology of Augustine's *sermones* on the agenda

dating of Augustine's preaching activities in general and his travelling, see Perler/Maier, *Les voyages de saint Augustin*.

of scholarly debate again.²⁵ Hombert uses the method of dating works of Augustine drafted by A.-M. La Bonnardière, which consists in the tracing of parallel Scripture references.²⁶ Hombert insists that where concrete information, such as allusion to historical events, places, a specific audience and other *realia* is absent, we are left with nothing more than the systematic exploration of scriptural parallels to substantiate dating the *sermones*. The meticulous comparison of texts in terms of vocabulary and *orchestration scripturaire* allows us, he argues, to collect precise chronological data. Hombert is well aware that a chronological study based on internal criteria is not without its problems. First, he agrees that it is not possible to locate every theological theme and biblical reference. Second, he insists that we must account for the fact that the majority of Augustine's *sermones* have not been preserved. Third, he is aware that parallel concentrations of biblical references need not necessarily imply parallel dates. Finally, it is important to be on the lookout for statistic exceptions. If 95% of a given concentration can be located in a particular time period in Augustine's writings, it is possible that the date of the concentration under analysis is to be found among the other 5%. Hombert argues that this method can be applied appropriately to the sermons of Augustine if it is supported by the convergence of various pieces of information, an accumulation of evidence and a separate judgement on each individual sermon.

H.R. Drobner does not agree, however, and insists that clear dating can only be realized on the basis of established external dating or an internal allusion to a *sermo* that can be related to an externally datable fact.²⁷ "Unfortunately, not a single one of all the *Sermones ad populum* can definitely be dated by day, month and year. The maximum we have are firmly established *termini ante quem* and *termini post quem*, which, if they both apply to the same sermon, determine a reliable time range."²⁸ Drobner rejects arguments such as "similar content means similar date of composition" and "similar style means similar date of composition", as he can see no reason to deny that Augustine returned to certain topics later in his career or that he returned to a particular style years after first employing it.²⁹

25 Hombert, *Nouvelles recherches de chronologie augustinienne*.

26 La Bonnardière, *Recherches de chronologie augustinienne*.

27 Drobner, "The Chronology of St. Augustine's *Sermones ad populum*"; Drobner, "The Chronology of St. Augustine's *Sermones ad populum* II"; Drobner, "The Chronology of St. Augustine's *Sermones ad populum* III".

28 Drobner, "The Chronology of St. Augustine's 'Sermones ad populum'", p. 212.

29 *Contra* Dolbeau, Drobner also rejects the thesis that the sequence of *sermones* found in Possidius' *Indiculus* (cf. *infra*) can have any chronological value. According to Dolbeau,

In practice, Drobner's criteria result in concrete dating very rarely. The maintenance of a happy medium is perhaps the best policy. Where *realia* are present, they should be used. F. Dolbeau has argued that thematic parallels have the potential to generate results in terms of dating, but only if they are treated with the required caution and tested against other data.³⁰

2.3 *Pseudo-Material and Authenticity*

There are several hundred apocryphal sermons attributed to Augustine. I. Machielsen's *Clavis Patristica pseudepigraphorum Medii Aevi* provides an important tool for the identification of pseudo-Augustinian writings.³¹ Inauthentic pieces have made their way into even some of the oldest collections of Augustine's sermons. Many sermons preached by early preachers like Heraclius, Quoduultdeus, Fulgentius of Ruspe, and Caesarius of Arles have been transmitted under the name of Augustine.³² One of the most popular series of pseudo-Augustinian sermons were the *Sermones ad fratres in eremo*, a 14th-century forgery in favor of the claim that the Order of Hermits of St. Augustine directly derived from communities formed by Augustine.³³ The collection was printed several times under the name of Augustine from 1477 onwards. It was Erasmus who recognized the *Sermones ad fratres in eremo* as inauthentic. A highly influential pseudo-Augustinian sermon is the *Sermo contra Iudaeos, paganos, et Arianos*. The sermon is generally considered to be the work of Augustine's near-contemporary Quoduultdeus.³⁴ In their edition of the *sermones ad populum*, the Maurists inserted a separate category for the so-called *sermones dubii*, which contains s. 364-94.

Distinguishing the genuine from the pseudo material is an ongoing process. Scholars tasked with assessing the authenticity of a sermon can rely on a few sources contemporary to Augustine's time. Though Augustine did not create the volume on the sermons that he intended, his *Retractationes* contain useful information. The most important contemporary source, however, is the *Indiculus*, a list of Augustine's works that was added by Possidius to the *Vita Augustini* which he wrote shortly after Augustine's death. The list is divided

sermons proximate to one another in the *Indiculus* were probably preached at more or less the same time. Chronology, in his opinion, is probably the structuring principle of the sequence found in the *Indiculus*. See Dolbeau, "Discussion of: H.R. Drobner".

30 Dolbeau, "Discussion of: H.R. Drobner".

31 Machielsen, *Clavis patristica pseudepigraphorum medii aevi*. Cf. Gryson, *Répertoire général des auteurs ecclésiastiques latins* (though inaccuracies are rife in this work).

32 Hamman, "La transmission des sermons de saint Augustin".

33 Saak, "On the origins of the OESA".

34 Sturges, "Pseudo-Augustinian Writings".

into ten sections. The first nine present Augustine's works as a body of mainly polemical works, listing in each section consecutively *libri/epistolae/tractatus*, the latter meaning sermons, though a relatively small number is mentioned in these first sections. The tenth section, however, containing *diuersi*, lists references to the *Enarrationes* and the *Tractatus in euangelium Iohannis*, along with some 200 sermon titles (X⁶, 1-199.202).³⁵ A large part of these titles has been tentatively identified with sermons that have been transmitted to us. Obviously, the *Indiculus* does not list all known sermons by Augustine, but the criteria used for including a sermon remain elusive. In addition to this historical evidence for a sermon's authenticity, scholars use a number of intrinsic criteria. A systematic enumeration and a practical application of these criteria for Augustine may be found in C. Weidmann.³⁶

A second avenue regarding research into pseudo-Augustinian sermons is the quest for authentic words and/or larger textual segments in otherwise inauthentic contexts. Many preachers in Late Antiquity and the early Middle Ages composed their own texts using authentic material. Most of these texts are either transmitted anonymously or attributed to Augustine. Examples used in recent research by C. Weidmann are the collections assembled by Caesarius of Arles and the African collection of "Pseudo-Fulgentius".³⁷ This type of research has yielded smaller additions to the text of a sermon,³⁸ but also longer passages. For instance, s. 167 was transmitted both as an Augustinian sermon in the *De uerbis apostoli* collection and also as *Caes.* 181, in which form it contains an additional paragraph of which C. Weidmann has convincingly proven the authenticity.³⁹

3 Augustine's Preaching

3.1 *Preparation, Style, and Structure*

Augustine did not write down his sermons in advance. Rather, he preached extemporaneously after preparing himself by reading Scripture and by prayer

35 Madec, "Possidius de Calama et les listes des œuvres d'Augustin"; Dolbeau, "La survie des œuvres d'Augustin".

36 Weidmann, "Sermo Mai 10".

37 Weidmann, "Discovering Augustine's Words in Pseudo-Augustinian Sermons".

38 E.g. in s. 178, preserved in the *De uerbis Apostoli* collection and in an adapted version by Caesarius of Arles, the latter preserved a phrase (*Praecedant magis quo secuturus es*) lost from the former collection through *saut du même au même*. Weidmann, "Discovering Augustine's Words in Pseudo-Augustinian Sermons", p. 45.

39 Weidmann, "Discovering Augustine's Words in Pseudo-Augustinian Sermons", pp. 46-49.

and reflection. The absence of formal preparation is evident from the liveliness of his sermons and the unexpected turns they often take. His relaxed homiletic style allowed him to respond to the mood and unforeseen reactions of his audience.

In order to ensure their accessibility, Augustine referred to concrete events and borrowed examples from everyday life in his sermons. He also demonstrated a preference for explaining matters in figurative language.⁴⁰ One of his favorite rhetorical figures was the *dialecticon*: a dialogue with an invented partner.⁴¹ Augustine posed questions or appeals directly to the Lord himself, or the apostles, or to imaginary opponents. He also made use of humor, wordplay and other rhetorical devices.⁴² In other words, he made full use of his erudi-

40 Poque, *Le langage symbolique*.

41 *Sermo* 165 (Carthage, 417) contains a clear example of a *dialecticon*. In a pointed fictive dialogue Augustine observes that his “Pelagian opponent” – who accepts physical death to be a punishment for sin – still does not conclude that the death of new-born infants is caused by original sin. He has his opponent stubbornly insist that God creates the human persons as immortal. The death of new-born infants must thus be caused by personal sin, committed between conception and death. Augustine thus makes his opponents, the *novelli* (the “Pelagians”) absurdly argue that the death of infants is the result of sins committed in the womb. Augustine’s “opponents” claim in addition that newborn infants simply sin by being born. Augustine responds with an example. Infants that die in the womb have not sinned (by being born), yet they still die (s. 165, 8). His “opponent” responds that foetuses can sin *in utero*. This idea, however, cannot be associated with any known “Pelagian” protagonist. While it is possible that it stems from a hitherto unidentified supporter, it is also possible that it has its roots in unfounded rumor. But it seems more likely that we are dealing with a systematization concocted by the opponents of the “Pelagians”, which the “Pelagians” themselves did not adhere to and may even have rejected. On the basis of a rhetorical analysis, Partoens has demonstrated that s. 165, 7–8, in which the so-called “Pelagian” claims are condemned, is more rhetorical and satirical by nature than polemic. In addition to the entire rhetorical structure of these paragraphs, the condemned positions are the result of a *reductio ad absurdum*, and do not represent positions actually maintained by the “Pelagians”. See Partoens, “Augustine on Predestination, Immortal Babies and Sinning Foetuses”.

42 By way of *casus*, Mayer summarizes the style figures employed by Augustine in his *sermones* dedicated to the protomartyr Stephen (s. 314, 315, 316, 317, 318, 319, 319A, 320, 321, 322, 323, 324, 382): “Alliteration: 82, Anapher: 53, Antithese: 68, Asyndeton: 30, Chiasmus: 14, Comparison: 2, Epipher: 10, Etymologie: 3, Geminatio: 2, Hendiadyoin: 3, Homoioteleuton: 1, Klimax: 3, Metapher: 11, Nominalstil: 14, Oxymoron: 9, Paronomasie: 7, Personifikation: 3, Randstellung: 56, rhetorische Frage: 26, Ringkomposition: 2, Sermocinatio: 13, Similitudo: 7, Sperrung: 21, Wortspiel: 2.” Mayer, “Attende Stephanum conservum tuum”, esp. p. 225. Cf. Oroz Reta, *La retórica en los Sermones de S. Agustín*.

tion to reach and convince his audience in an agreeable manner.⁴³ Augustine's desire to keep his sermons as simple as possible in terms of language, style and explanation, was not only motivated by practical, didactic goals rooted in his pastoral concern to be accessible to all, but it also had a theological motivation. According to Augustine, the simplicity of a sermon represented the imitation of Christ's humility.⁴⁴ In his *De doctrina christiana* Augustine presented two methods for the study of the Scriptures: the acquisition of insight into the Bible and the presentation thereof. Explaining the latter *modus proferendi*, Augustine made an appeal for eloquence and authenticity. Preachers should prepare their homilies with care, should live an exemplary life, and should commit themselves to prayer. In *De doctrina christiana* Augustine revealed himself to be loyal to his own rhetorical formation by advocating the use of classical rhetoric in the service of Christian proclamation. L. Mechlinsky argues that Augustine's sermons are constructed according to the rhetorical-stylistic structure of *prooemium*, *narratio*, *argumentatio*, and *peroratio*.⁴⁵ Somewhat more nuanced, A. Eelen distinguishes three primary structural types within the corpus of s. 157-83: (1) the classical *quaestio*-structure, (2) a hybrid form where the classical structure of the sermon is influenced by the Scripture reading that preceded the sermon, the liturgical context, related sermons, or other literary genres, and (3) a structure which follows that of an exegetical commentary.⁴⁶

3.2 Content

G. Lawless offers a sketch of Augustine's understanding of the profile of the preacher:

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- 43 Mohrmann writes on Augustine's homiletic style and language: "... saint Augustin a consciemment créé un style homilétique qui devait répondre aux besoins de la prédication populaire. Dans ce style il recherche trois choses: en premier lieu et avant tout la clarté, puis l'expressivité, et en troisième lieu la gravité, l'onction." Augustine achieved the clarity he desired by using a stylized form of Latin that was spoken in cultivated circles but was also presumably accessible to the ordinary man and woman in the street on account of its relative simplicity. The use of style figures (especially parallelism and antithesis) granted Augustine's sermons an expressive character, while the contribution of biblical texts (quotations, allusions) guaranteed their gravity. Mohrmann, "Saint Augustin prédicateur", esp. pp. 396-400.
- 44 Berrouard, "Saint Augustin et le ministère de la prédication"; Schnitzler, *Zur Theologie der Verkündigung*.
- 45 Mechlinsky, *Der 'modus proferendi' in Augustins 'sermones ad populum'*.
- 46 Eelen, *Les sermons de saint Augustin sur les épîtres du Nouveau Testament*, esp. pp. 470-96. See also Van Neer, "Scripture as the Structuring Principle of Sermones 295 and 299B".

During the last decade of his eventful life, ... the bishop of Hippo offered two mature estimates, respectively, of a preacher and his responsibilities. In the first he furnished a succinctly instructive account of who a preacher is: "We are ministers of the Word, not ours, but God's, certainly, and our Lord's" (s. 114, 1). The second provided a detailed description, reflecting four decades of pastoral experience, of the preacher's task: "he (1) interprets and teaches the divine Scriptures; (2) defends right faith; (3) teaches everything that is good; (4) un-teaches anything evil; (5) endeavors to win over individuals hostile to truth; (6) arouses careless individuals; (7) impresses upon ignorant people what's happening; and (8) impresses upon them what to expect (*doc. Chr.* 4, 4, 6).⁴⁷

C. Mohrmann points out with respect to the content of the sermons that Augustine dealt with all sorts of difficult subjects:

... tout ce que saint Augustin a traité dans ses travaux revient pratiquement dans sa prédication. Même les questions théologiques les plus difficiles et les plus abstraites, comme sa théologie trinitaire, sont discutées dans ses sermons. ... C'est un fait remarquable que ce prédicateur qui s'efforce de parler une langue simple et compréhensible, qui fait des concessions à ses auditeurs en ce qui concerne la forme extérieure de sa prédication, ne leur relâche rien quand il s'agit de la doctrine. La prédication augustinienne revêt un caractère nettement théologique et spéculatif.⁴⁸

M. Pellegrino reviews a number of theological themes discussed in Augustine's sermons: Trinitarianism, Christology, pneumatology, ecclesiology, sacraments, the Eucharist, the forgiveness of sins, and eschatology. In this sense, Augustine's sermons are theologically informed and catechetical by nature.⁴⁹ Augustine's sermons also address questions related to the practice of living the Christian life.⁵⁰ A portion of Augustine's sermons have a polemical purpose and content, sometimes explicit and sometimes less so, rebuking the theology of the Manicheans, Donatists, Pelagians, and others.

47 Lawless, "Preaching", esp. p. 675.

48 Mohrmann, "Saint Augustin prédicateur", esp. p. 402.

49 Grasser, "La catéchèse d'Augustin dans le cadre liturgique".

50 Pellegrino, "General Introduction", esp. pp. 56-83.

3.3 *Relation to Scripture*

G.G. Willis, S. Poque, A.-M. La Bonnardière, V. Saxer, and M. Margoni-Kögler have endeavored on the basis of Augustine's sermons to reconstruct his *lectionarium*.⁵¹ It is evident that the Scriptures represent the essential point of the sermons and Augustine often referred to the liturgical Bible readings in his homilies. Augustine's theology is biblically inspired, as can be said of patristic theology as a whole. However, Augustine was free on ordinary days to choose a reading in function of the topic he wished to address. In this sense, the readings were sometimes no more than an occasion to draw attention to a theme. Nevertheless, Augustine's preaching was biblical to the core and none of his homilies are without biblical quotations. Indeed, certain biblical texts are ascribed an important place in his theology, particularly his "controversial theology", his debates with the Manicheans, Donatists, and Pelagians. References to Scripture in the sermons, however, were not always explicit. In fact, his choice of words often suggested that he was alluding to a particular biblical verse without naming it. Augustine also combined apparently unrelated verses because they carried the same meaning in his view. One pericope led to another based perhaps on nothing more than a shared word or a related theme. According to Augustine, exposition of the Bible should proceed according to the following set of rules. Every explanation of a text must be in accordance with the *regula fidei*. The Scriptures should be understood *spiritualiter* and not *carnaliter*. The biblical texts constitute a radical unity. The Bible thus has to be explained by the Bible. At the same time, the Bible should always be read from a Christian perspective and the Old Testament read allegorically and typologically in light of the New Testament. In addition to these theological instruments, based on the conviction that the Bible is inspired, Augustine also made use of philological instruments: respect for the text, comparison of variant codices, reference to Greek biblical texts, and the recognition that a given word can have a different meaning in a different context. Augustine details and elaborates these exegetical and hermeneutical principles in his *De doctrina christiana*.⁵²

3.4 *Audience*

The public reacted to Augustine's words in a variety of different ways. Sometimes the audience was attentive and demonstrated their agreement with

51 Willis, *St. Augustine's Lectionary*; Poque, *Augustin d'Hippone*; La Bonnardière, "La Bible liturgique de saint Augustin"; Saint Augustin, *L'année liturgique*, ed./trans. Saxer; Margoni-Kögler, *Die Perikopen im Gottesdienst bei Augustinus*.

52 Pontet, *L'exégèse de S. Augustin prédicateur*.

acclamations and applause. At other times they were restless and distracted and demonstrated their annoyance at what was being preached. *Sermones* 293-94, preached in Carthage in the summer of 413 AD, aptly illustrate the latter. In these sermons, Augustine indicated that when unbaptized infants die, they suffer eternal damnation on account of original sin. The content of the two sermons shows that his audience did not agree with this position and actually protested. Augustine's listeners probably did not constitute a homogeneous group, but represented diverse social statuses, lifestyles, educational backgrounds, and intellectual perspectives. According to R. MacMullen, Augustine's listeners were for the most part well-to-do, although greater diversity was evident during the major liturgical feasts.⁵³ M. Pellegrino takes the social homogeneity of those who attended Augustine's sermons as his point of departure.⁵⁴ G. Partoens points out, however, that Augustine himself made regular reference to the intellectual and spiritual heterogeneity of his public.⁵⁵ It is probable that the majority of his listeners had little knowledge of classical literature, although their potential knowledge of the Bible should not be underestimated. C. Mohrmann argues on the basis of reactions from his listeners that the majority were generally able to follow the difficult theological and exegetical issues raised in the sermons. The North African public appears to have had a lively interest in theological matters.⁵⁶

3.5 *Research Perspectives*

The study of the content of Augustine's sermons has a twofold importance. First, an analysis of the theological content of the sermons can provide insight into Augustine's pastoral and spiritual perspective on topics in philosophical theology. The primary difference between his doctrinal writings and his homilies is rooted in the latter's concrete liturgical context and their direct contact with a (mostly) sympathetic audience. The style of the sermons, the majority of which are occasional writings, reveals an additional difference: Augustine's pastoral and spiritual vision of philosophical theology and the practical application of doctrinal propositions. Second, the study of the sermons represents a complement to existing philosophical theological research into Augustine's thought. His sermons do not limit themselves to the spiritual and practical pastoral perspective, but engage on occasion with the topics in philosophical

53 MacMullen, "The Preacher's Audience (AD 350-400)", esp. p. 505, pp. 508-10. See also Marin, "Aspetti dell'omiletica agostiniana".

54 Pellegrino, "General Introduction", esp. pp. 85-87.

55 Partoens, "Augustin als Prediger", esp. p. 245.

56 Mohrmann, "Saint Augustin prédicateur", esp. p. 402.

theology that he dealt with in his doctrinal writings. The difference lies in the fact that the homilies often offer a simplified discussion of these topics, bearing in mind the capacities of his public. The sermons thus exhibit a combination of Augustine the pastor-preacher and Augustine the theologian. From a research perspective, moreover, the sermons have the additional advantage that they present an overview of the entire period of almost forty years in which Augustine was theologically active.⁵⁷

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57 Partoens, "Augustin als Prediger", esp. pp. 246-47.

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